UNIT 2 · CHAPTER 8 · A NEW BIRTH OF FREEDOM — DEEP DIVE

Gettysburg

Three days in a small Pennsylvania town — July 1–3, 1863 — that changed what the war was about.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Three days in a small Pennsylvania town — July 1–3, 1863 — that changed what the war was about.

Why do we still call three days at one Pennsylvania crossroads the turning point of the Civil War?

Lee Gambles on the North

WHY IT HAPPENED

By the summer of 1863 the war had been fought mostly on Southern ground, and Virginia was exhausted. Fresh from a stunning victory at Chancellorsville, Confederate General Robert E. Lee made a bold decision: carry the war into the North.

A win on Union soil might threaten Washington or Philadelphia, feed his army from Northern farms, strengthen Northerners who wanted peace, and even push Britain or France to recognize the Confederacy. So Lee's Army of Northern Virginia marched north — toward Pennsylvania.

The Road to Gettysburg

THE MARCH

Up the Shenandoah Valley, across the Potomac, into Pennsylvania — until the roads all met at one town.

Lee marches north — the road to Gettysburg

A Battle No One Planned

DAY ONE · JULY 1

Neither army chose Gettysburg. The armies collided almost by accident when Confederate troops looking for supplies ran into Union cavalry under General John Buford west of town.

Buford's outnumbered men fought a delaying action on the ridges, buying time for the Union infantry to arrive. Confederates pushed the Union back through the streets of Gettysburg — but the Northerners rallied on the high ground just south of town. General John Reynolds, one of the Union's best, was killed in the morning fighting.

The Fishhook

THE GROUND · THREE DAYS

The Union held a line of hills shaped like a fishhook. Step through the three days — July 1, 2, 3 — or press Play all.

The fishhook — three days on the same ground

Whoever Holds the Hills

DAY ONE · THE STAKES

That first day set the terms for everything after it. The Union ended July 1 bruised but holding the heights — Cemetery Hill, Culp's Hill, and the long spine of Cemetery Ridge.

High ground meant the defenders could see the field, move troops quickly along the inside of the fishhook, and force the attackers to charge uphill. For the next two days, Lee would try to break that line — and the ground would fight against him.

The Flanks Hold

DAY TWO · JULY 2

On the second day Lee struck both ends of the Union line at once. The fighting was some of the most savage of the entire war, at places whose names became famous: Little Round Top, Devil's Den, the Wheatfield, the Peach Orchard, and Culp's Hill.

At the far left end of the line, Colonel Joshua Chamberlain and the 20th Maine ran out of ammunition — and held anyway, with a downhill bayonet charge. By nightfall the Union line had bent in places but had not broken.

Pickett's Charge

DAY THREE · JULY 3

Having failed at the ends, Lee gambled on the center. After the largest artillery bombardment of the war, about 12,500 Confederate soldiers stepped out of the trees on Seminary Ridge and marched across three-quarters of a mile of open field toward the Union center.

They walked into massed cannon and rifle fire the whole way. A few hundred reached the Union line at a spot called the Angle — the farthest point the Confederacy would ever reach, remembered as the “high-water mark.” Then the charge collapsed and the survivors streamed back. Lee is said to have ridden among them saying, “It is all my fault.”

What Three Days Weighed

THE COST

Roughly 51,000 soldiers on both sides were killed, wounded, captured, or missing — the bloodiest battle ever fought in North America. A town of 2,400 people was left with thousands of dead and wounded, and more dead horses than it could bury.

Numbers this large stop meaning much on their own. The work of the next slides — and of the man who came in November — was to make them mean something.

The Tide Goes Out

THE TURNING POINT

On July 4, 1863, Lee began the long retreat back to Virginia. His army was never strong enough to invade the North again.

The very same day, far to the west, the city of Vicksburg surrendered to Ulysses S. Grant, giving the Union control of the Mississippi River and splitting the Confederacy in two. Historians have long argued about single "turning points," but that July 4 is widely seen as the day the war tilted toward the Union — even though nearly two more years of fighting lay ahead.

Two Blows in One Week

EAST AND WEST

As Lee retreated, Vicksburg fell to Grant far to the west — and the Mississippi split the Confederacy in two.

Two blows, one week — East and West, July 1863

A Field Full of Graves

AFTER THE BATTLE

The armies marched away; the dead stayed. Thousands of Union soldiers had been buried quickly and badly where they fell. To give them a proper resting place, Pennsylvania and other Northern states created a Soldiers' National Cemetery on the battlefield.

It would be dedicated on November 19, 1863. The main speaker was the famous orator Edward Everett, who spoke for two hours. Almost as an afterthought, the organizers also invited the President to add "a few appropriate remarks."

NOVEMBER 19, 1863

…that this nation, under God, shall have a new birth of freedom—

— ABRAHAM LINCOLN, AT THE DEDICATION OF THE CEMETERY

272 Words

THE SPEECH

Lincoln spoke for about two minutes. In a few sentences he did something the two-hour speech before him did not: he told the country what the war was for.

He reached past the Constitution all the way back to the Declaration of Independence — "all men are created equal" — and argued that the soldiers had died so that promise could finally be kept. Saving the

Union was no longer enough; the war was now for a “new birth of freedom.” That single phrase is the name of this chapter.

From a Battle to a Meaning

WHY IT MATTERS

Follow this chapter's threads. Belonging — who counts as one of “we the people” — and Voice — who gets to say so — both turn here. Gettysburg broke the Confederacy's best chance to win outright; the Address redefined the war as one for equality, pointing straight toward emancipation and the amendments to come.

This is the hinge of Chapter 8, A New Birth of Freedom. The battle decided that the Union would survive. The speech decided what kind of Union it would try to become.

Read the Address Again

YOUR TURN

Lincoln got the whole meaning of the war into 272 words. Now read them closely — like a historian — and defend what you find.